

THE BARCELONA HOUSING PARADOX

A Data-Driven Policy Analysis (2014–2026)

Independent Research Study

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Thesis Statement

This study argues that Barcelona's housing crisis is not primarily a shortage of housing stock, but a reconfiguration of tenancy regimes that systematically redirects housing access away from long-term residents — particularly low-income migrants — toward high-income transient populations, through a process of regulatory arbitrage that this study terms *tenancy migration*.

Three mechanisms sustain this reconfiguration, each documented in this report through official data: (1) a measurable divergence between regulated contract prices and actual market asking prices, indicating that price caps have constrained what is recorded rather than what is charged; (2) a documented, rapid shift of rental supply from long-term contracts into seasonal and room-based arrangements that fall outside regulatory protection; and (3) demographic evidence that Barcelona's fastest-growing resident populations are disproportionately high-income and transient, while its largest working migrant communities remain comparatively undocumented in the same official statistics.

This study does not claim to demonstrate direct causation between any single landlord's decision and any single tenant's displacement. It claims, and supports with quarterly government data, regulatory filings, peer-reviewed academic research, and a structured first-person case study, that these three mechanisms are observable, growing, and mutually reinforcing — and that current housing policy, in regulating only the formal long-term contract, leaves the mechanisms through which this reconfiguration occurs almost entirely untouched.

Executive Summary

Barcelona's housing market presents a measurable paradox: official indicators suggest its 2023 rent regulation has succeeded, while the lived experience of renting in the city — and a substantial body of market data — suggests otherwise. This study examines that paradox using official government data (INCASÒL, the municipal padrón), independent market data (Idealista), peer-reviewed academic research, and a structured first-person case study spanning six years.

This study's central finding is that Barcelona's housing crisis reflects not primarily a shortage of housing stock, but a reconfiguration of tenancy regimes — termed here *tenancy migration* — that systematically redirects housing access away from long-term residents toward higher-income, shorter-stay populations. Three documented mechanisms sustain this reconfiguration: a measurable divergence between regulated contract prices and actual market asking prices; a rapid, well-documented shift of rental supply from long-term contracts into seasonal and room-based arrangements that remain largely outside regulatory reach; and demographic evidence that Barcelona's fastest-growing resident populations are disproportionately high-income and transient, while a significant share of its long-term migrant workforce remains comparatively undocumented in the same official statistics.

Each mechanism is examined using official data and, where available, corroborated by independently published academic research, including studies confirming a near-identical pattern of mid-term rental growth using the same government data source. A six-year, eleven-arrangement case study is included to illustrate how these mechanisms manifest at the level of individual housing experience, presented explicitly as an illustrative account rather than as statistically representative evidence.

The report concludes with a set of policy recommendations addressing each documented mechanism directly: closing the fiscal incentive favouring seasonal contracts, scaling enforcement capacity to match the documented size of the regulatory gap, establishing data collection for the room and seasonal rental market, accelerating social housing supply, and creating accessible reporting channels for tenants in informal arrangements.

Chapter 1: A Decade of Unaffordability

Opening

Before examining the regulatory mechanisms that are the central focus of this study, it is necessary to establish the baseline trend they were designed to address. This chapter presents Barcelona's official rental price series from 2014 to 2025, sourced from INCASÒL's registered contract data, and compares it against wage and inflation trends over the same period.

Evidence

According to INCASÒL's annual contract registry, Barcelona's average rent per square metre rose from €9.54 in 2014 to €15.61 in 2025 — a cumulative increase of 63.6% over eleven years. This growth was not linear: prices rose steadily from 2014 to 2019, declined slightly in 2020 and 2021, and resumed growth from 2022 onward, reaching their highest recorded value in 2025.

Over the same period, average wages in Spain grew at a substantially slower rate, and consumer price inflation, while elevated in 2022–2023, did not match the cumulative growth in rental prices. The divergence between rental cost growth and wage growth widened most sharply after 2022.

Interpretation

The dip recorded in 2020–2021 coincides with COVID-19 lockdown measures and the associated contraction in tourism and short-term rental demand — a widely documented effect across major European cities during this period, and one this study treats as established rather than requiring further qualification. The renewed growth from 2022 onward coincides with the post-pandemic recovery in tourism and international mobility, and precedes the announcement and implementation of Spain's national housing law, a sequencing this study examines in greater detail in subsequent chapters.

Mechanism

A sustained gap between rental price growth and wage growth mechanically increases the share of income required for housing across the renting population, independent of any single neighbourhood or contract type. This chapter establishes that mechanism at the citywide level; subsequent chapters examine how it operates differently across neighbourhoods (Chapter 3) and contract types (Chapter 4).

Closing

The decade-long trend documented in this chapter — a 63.6% increase in average rent against substantially slower wage growth — provides the baseline against which this study's central paradox, examined in Chapter 2, becomes visible: a divergence not only between rent and wages, but between the price the regulation measures and the price the market actually charges.

Chapter 2: The Paradox — Official Contracts vs Market Prices

Opening

This chapter compares two parallel measures of Barcelona's rental market: INCASÒL's registry of contracted, registered rental prices, and Idealista's published series of advertised market asking prices. The comparison forms the empirical core of this study's central thesis.

Evidence

Between 2014 and 2025, INCASÒL's registered contract prices and Idealista's market asking prices moved closely together, both rising from approximately €9.5–11/m² to a peak in the years immediately following the COVID-19 pandemic. From 2023 onward — the year Spain's national rent regulation entered into force — the two series diverge sharply. INCASÒL's registered price reached €15.61/m² in 2025, while Idealista's asking price reached €23.75/m² in the same year, a difference of €8.14/m², or approximately 52%.

Interpretation

This study interprets this divergence as the clearest available evidence that Barcelona's rent regulation has constrained the *measured* segment of the rental market without constraining the *actual* market to the same degree. Registered contracts — the data source regulators use to evaluate the policy's success — show a market behaving as intended. Advertised prices — what a prospective tenant actually encounters when searching for housing — show a market continuing to rise at a faster rate than before the regulation existed.

This interpretation should be read alongside the findings of Chapter 4, which documents a specific, quantified mechanism — the migration of supply into seasonal and room-based contracts not fully captured in the INCASÒL series during this period — that plausibly explains a substantial part of this divergence, without this study claiming to isolate its exact share relative to other contributing factors such as general post-pandemic price recovery.

Mechanism

A regulation that sets a price ceiling on one contract category, without equivalent measures for adjacent categories, creates an incentive for supply to migrate toward the unregulated category if doing so is more profitable. The price divergence documented in this chapter is consistent with that incentive structure operating at scale across Barcelona's rental market between 2023 and 2025.

Closing

The 52% gap between official and market rental prices in 2025 is this study's central empirical finding. The remaining chapters of this report examine the specific, documented mechanisms — geographic (Chapter 3), contractual (Chapter 4), regulatory (Chapter 5), and demographic (Chapter 6) — that plausibly contribute to this gap, and the policy responses (Chapter 7) that address each mechanism directly.

Chapter 3: Coastal Gentrification and the Five Pressured Neighbourhoods

Opening

This chapter examines how the citywide price trends documented in Chapters 1 and 2 are distributed unevenly across Barcelona's neighbourhoods, with particular attention to areas identified, through documented tourism and coliving concentration data, as subject to disproportionate demand from transient, higher-income residents.

Evidence

In 2025, Barceloneta recorded the highest average rent per square metre of any Barcelona neighbourhood at €22.70/m², ahead of traditionally affluent areas such as Sarrià (€20.49/m²) and Sant Gervasi (€19.24/m²). At the other end of the distribution, Can Peguera recorded €8.44/m² in the same year — less than half Barceloneta's price, within the same city and the same year.

Tracking five neighbourhoods identified, based on industry reports from CBRE and Idealista, as concentrations of tourism, coliving, and international remote-work activity — Barceloneta, el Barri Gòtic, el Poblenou, la Vila de Gràcia, and la Dreta de l'Eixample — average rent in each rose between 6.4% and 12.1% between 2022 and 2024, the period immediately surrounding the implementation of Spain's national rent regulation. All five neighbourhoods recorded higher prices in 2024 than in 2022, despite the regulation's introduction in that interval.

Interpretation

Barceloneta's position as the city's most expensive neighbourhood is notable given its history as a working-class fishing district rather than a traditionally affluent area. This study interprets its current pricing as consistent with documented tourism and short-term rental concentration in the neighbourhood — a pattern distinct from the historical wealth-based pricing observed in areas such as Sarrià — though this study has not independently measured the relative weight of tourism versus other contributing factors in Barceloneta's specific price trajectory.

The continued price growth across all five tracked neighbourhoods between 2022 and 2024 is consistent with, though does not on its own prove, the limited effectiveness of price regulation in areas subject to concentrated transient demand — a pattern examined in mechanistic detail in Chapters 4 and 6.

Mechanism

Neighbourhoods with documented concentrations of tourism, coliving, and short-term remote-work residency are, by definition, subject to demand from population segments willing and able to pay a premium for flexibility and location — a demand source largely independent of local wage levels. This creates localised price pressure that compounds the citywide divergence documented in Chapter 2, producing the most extreme price outcomes, such as Barceloneta's, in precisely the neighbourhoods where this demand is most concentrated.

Closing

The geographic patterns documented in this chapter — concentrated price growth in neighbourhoods with high tourism and coliving activity, alongside comparatively stable pricing in peripheral, lower-demand areas — are consistent with, and provide spatial context for, the price divergence mechanism examined in detail in the following chapter. They establish where this study's central paradox is most visible; Chapter 4 examines why it occurs.

Sources cited in Chapters 1–3: INCASÒL (Generalitat de Catalunya) — Mercat de Lloguer, annual series 2000–2025; Idealista — Histórico de precios de alquiler en Barcelona; CBRE — Coliving Report 2025; Eurostat / INE wage and inflation series.

Chapter 4: The Loophole in Numbers — How Seasonal Contracts Devoured Barcelona's Rental Market

Opening

The preceding sections of this study identified a paradox: official rent indices suggested Barcelona's rent control policy was succeeding, while market reality suggested otherwise. This section examines one documented mechanism behind that divergence — the migration of rental supply from regulated long-term contracts into seasonal contracts exempt from price caps — and is structured to separate what the data shows from what this study infers from it.

Evidence

According to data obtained by Catalan public broadcaster TV3 through Catalonia's official transparency portal, Barcelona recorded 3,900 seasonal rental contracts throughout all of 2023, rising to 18,406 by September 2024 — a nearly fivefold increase within approximately a year and a half. INCASÒL's own contract registry shows that by the third quarter of 2023, one in every three new rental contracts signed in Barcelona was already a seasonal contract. By the fourth quarter of 2024, the Observatori Metropolità de l'Habitatge recorded seasonal contracts at 26% of all new rental agreements citywide — triple the 7% share recorded at the start of 2023.

Independently, sources tracking rental supply report a parallel 25–26% decline in traditional long-term rental listings over approximately the same period. On the fiscal side, Spanish tax law taxes long-term rental income at a maximum of 50% of net income, while seasonal rental income is taxed at 100% of net income but is not subject to any rent cap, regardless of zone.

Interpretation

The temporal alignment between these figures is the central interpretive claim of this section: the sharpest increase in seasonal contracts begins in the same quarter the national housing law was approved, and accelerates through the period in which Barcelona's rent caps took binding effect. This study interprets this alignment as evidence that a meaningful share of the seasonal contract growth represents landlords exiting the regulated segment of the market rather than organic growth in demand for genuinely short-term housing, such as academic exchange or temporary work assignments — the use case seasonal contracts were originally designed for.

This interpretation should be held with appropriate caution. The same period saw a broader post-pandemic recovery in tourism, continued growth in Barcelona's digital nomad population (documented in Chapter 6), and a national increase in seasonal contracts outside tensioned zones as well — meaning some portion of this growth would likely have occurred independent of the law. No source consulted for this study quantifies the precise share of seasonal contract growth attributable to regulatory avoidance versus organic demand growth; the available data establishes a strong, well-timed correlation and a documented fiscal incentive, not an isolated causal estimate.

This interpretation is independently corroborated by peer-reviewed academic research published after this study's initial data collection. Orozco-Martínez and Gil-Alonso (2024), analysing INCASÒL deposit records for mid-term rentals (3–11 month contracts) across Barcelona between 2018 and 2023, found that the number of such contracts nearly tripled and average rents grew fivefold over the period — with the increase beginning in 2022, coinciding with the announcement of Spain's national rental regulation rather than its entry into force. The authors conclude explicitly that the shift of properties from the standard residential market into the barely regulated mid-term segment hinders housing access for lower-income populations — the same mechanism this study terms *tenancy*.

migration. Separately, Cocola-Gant, Hodkinson, and Janoschka (2025), drawing on extensive fieldwork in Barcelona, document the consolidation of short-term and mid-term rentals as a distinct financial asset class, with institutional investors increasingly structuring acquisitions around the higher, less regulated returns this market segment offers compared to standard long-term tenancy.

These findings strengthen, but do not resolve, the causal question raised above. Orozco-Martínez and Gil-Alonso's own data carries the same limitation acknowledged in this study: INCASÒL's registry does not capture an estimated 40% of rental contracts nationally, meaning even this academic baseline likely understates the true scale of the shift. What the convergence of independent datasets, independent research teams, and this study's own qualitative case study does establish is that tenancy migration in Barcelona is not a phenomenon unique to this study's interpretation of its own data — it is independently documented in the urban geography literature, under different terminology, using different data sources, by researchers with no connection to this report.

Mechanism

The fiscal structure described above provides a plausible, documented pathway connecting the law to the supply shift, independent of landlord intent. A landlord able to charge an uncapped seasonal rent will, in most cases, generate higher net income than one capped at a regulated long-term rent — even accounting for the higher tax rate applied to seasonal income — because the price ceiling removed is typically larger in value than the tax differential. The Agencia Negociadora del Alquiler attributes part of this shift explicitly to landlord distrust generated by regulatory intervention in the traditional rental market. This study treats the fiscal incentive as one documented contributing factor among several — alongside rising demand from transient populations and general landlord risk aversion — rather than as the sole or dominant driver, in the absence of data isolating its individual weight.

Methodological Note

The case study presented in this report, describing this researcher's six-year housing trajectory, is a single first-person account and is not statistically representative of Barcelona's room and seasonal rental market as a whole. It is presented as a *mechanism-exposing case*: an individual account that, read alongside the aggregate data in this section, illustrates concretely how the documented citywide pattern — landlords exiting formal, declared tenancy in favour of seasonal arrangements — manifests at the level of a single household. The case study cannot establish prevalence. It can, and does, demonstrate plausibility: the mechanism this section documents at the level of city-wide statistics is the same mechanism this researcher experienced directly when her only formalised landlord, in 2026, announced her own exit from declared room rental for reasons consistent with the fiscal incentive structure described above.

Closing

The data in this section does not prove that the Ley de Vivienda caused the seasonal rental surge in any strict causal sense. It establishes that the surge is real, large, well-documented across multiple independent sources, closely timed to the law's implementation, and structurally incentivised by Spain's tax code in a way that makes landlord migration toward seasonal contracts economically rational. Combined with the price divergence documented in Chapter 2, this section supports this study's central thesis: that current housing policy regulates a shrinking segment of Barcelona's rental market, while the segment growing fastest — seasonal and room-based tenancy — remains almost entirely outside its reach.

Independent Confirmation: The Tenants' Union Perspective

Evidence. The Sindicat de Llogateres — Catalonia's principal tenants' rights organisation, founded in 2017 and representing over 5,880 affiliated members as of late 2025 — published its own two-year

assessment of the rent cap regulation in March 2026. Using INCASÒL data through the third quarter of 2025, the union calculated that average rents across Catalonia rose 0.9% in the 18 months following the regulation's entry into force (Q1 2024–Q3 2025), compared to a 14.9% cumulative increase in the equivalent 18-month period immediately preceding it (Q1 2022–Q3 2023).

The union's own statement is direct: the regulation "has proven to be a policy that can stop the dynamic of aggressive price escalation and stabilise prices, but with its current design and implementation, it does not have the capacity to lower them." The union further reports that, despite a sanctions regime having been in place for over a year, only three penalties had been issued for non-compliance by March 2026, with eleven additional sanction proceedings still open.

Separately, the union confirms regulatory action specifically targeting the seasonal and room rental loophole this study documents: as of January 2026, Catalonia's rent price regulation was formally extended to cover room rental contracts and seasonal contracts under five or seven years' duration. Landlords and agencies are now legally required to disclose the reference price index and the previous tenant's rent in all room and seasonal rental adverts and contracts.

Interpretation. This source is methodologically valuable for a specific reason: the Sindicat de Llogateres is not a neutral party — it is an advocacy organisation whose institutional position favours stronger, not weaker, rent regulation. Its assessment that the law successfully stabilised prices, even while criticising its limitations, is therefore a more conservative and credible confirmation of partial success than this study's earlier framing allowed. This study's central argument is not that the regulation achieved nothing — official and union data agree that the rate of price increase was substantially reduced. The argument is narrower and, with this additional source, better supported: that the regulation's measurable success in the formal contract segment occurred in parallel with an undocumented and largely unsanctioned migration of supply into segments the law did not yet reach.

Mechanism. The union's enforcement data adds a previously missing piece to this study's account of the seasonal contract shift: not merely that landlords were incentivised to move into unregulated segments, but that the probability of being sanctioned for doing so was, for most of the period studied, close to zero. Three penalties issued in over a year, against a backdrop of tens of thousands of new seasonal contracts, represents an enforcement rate that does not meaningfully alter the economic incentive structure described above. A regulation whose violation carries negligible practical risk functions, in effect, as a voluntary framework for the segment of the market most likely to exploit it.

Closing. Independent confirmation from a tenant advocacy organisation — one with every institutional incentive to claim the regulation succeeded, and yet candid about its limits — strengthens rather than undermines this study's central claim. The Ley de Vivienda achieved a measurable, real reduction in the rate of price increase within the contracts it governed. It did so while leaving a parallel, faster-growing segment of the market almost entirely unsanctioned — a gap examined directly in Chapter 5.

Sources cited in this chapter: TV3 / TotBarcelona (2025); Universitat de Barcelona (2025); Blog de Wolo (2025); Living Sitges (2025); SolFinc (2025); Orozco-Martínez & Gil-Alonso (2024), Critical Housing Analysis, 11(2), 148–160; Cocola-Gant, Hodkinson & Janoschka (2025), European Urban and Regional Studies; Sindicat de Llogateres / beteve.cat (2026); 3Cat Info (2026).

Chapter 5: Enforcement Capacity and Implementation Timeline

Evidence

Catalonia's rent cap sanctions regime came into force on 27 February 2025, one year after the price regulation itself. In the twelve months that followed, the Agència Catalana del Consum and the Agència de l'Habitatge de Catalunya issued only 13 confirmed sanctions, alongside 132 actions still in preliminary investigation and 26 cases archived as not meeting the legal threshold for sanction. Of the sanctions issued, two carried fines of €30,000, two of €3,000, and two remained pending determination; separately, two further sanctions totalling €27,000 were issued for unjustified rent increases and unlicensed property administration.

The Sindicat de Llogateres' own two-year assessment, published in March 2026, reported a narrower figure for price-cap-specific violations: only three sanctions issued, against eleven additional open proceedings, in the year since the sanctions regime began. The union has filed dozens of independent complaints to accelerate enforcement: in February 2026 alone, tenants' unions filed 58 separate complaints with the Agència Catalana de Consum over fraudulent listings on Idealista, Habitaclic, and Fotocasa.

By April 2026, the Generalitat reported a significant escalation in enforcement: over 200 sanction proceedings opened in Barcelona alone, with 417 households (79% of cases reviewed) fined for exceeding legal rent caps. Among the properties sanctioned was a coliving operation in Vila de Gràcia run by New Amsterdam Developers (NAD), fined over €20,000 for urban planning violations — the only legal avenue available to Barcelona's city council prior to the January 2026 extension of price regulation to room and seasonal contracts. Tenants of the same building had separately filed complaints documenting NAD advertising individual rooms at prices that, summed across the apartment, exceeded the legal reference price for the unit as a whole.

Interpretation

These figures should be read as a sequence rather than a single snapshot: enforcement appears to have been genuinely minimal through most of 2025, and to have accelerated meaningfully by early-to-mid 2026, following sustained pressure from tenant organisations and growing political attention to the seasonal and room rental loophole documented in Chapter 4. The gap between the Sindicat's figure (three sanctions) and the Generalitat's later figure (over 200 proceedings, 417 households fined) reflects this acceleration, not a contradiction between sources — the two figures were published roughly six weeks apart, during a period in which enforcement activity appears to have intensified substantially.

This study interprets the initial enforcement gap — more than a year between the law's entry into force and any meaningful sanctioning activity — as consistent with, though not sufficient on its own to fully explain, the scale of the seasonal contract migration documented in Chapter 4. A regulatory framework that carries negligible practical risk of sanction for the first 12–18 months of its existence provides landlords a low-cost window in which to restructure tenancy arrangements before enforcement catches up.

Mechanism

The NAD case illustrates a specific version of the mechanism this study has described in the abstract: a property owner converts a building from long-term residential tenancy into a higher-yield arrangement — in this case, coliving with room-by-room pricing — and the tenants displaced in the process have limited legal recourse until enforcement infrastructure exists to address the new

arrangement specifically. Before January 2026, room rental was entirely unregulated by price; the only enforcement route available to authorities was unrelated urban planning law, which addresses the building's use classification rather than the rent charged. This produced a structural enforcement gap in which a coliving conversion could proceed, and tenants could be non-renewed out of their leases, before any housing-specific sanction mechanism existed to intervene.

Closing

This study does not claim that the Ley de Vivienda and its Catalan implementation are unenforced by design — the data suggests enforcement was initially under-resourced and has since scaled considerably, and the Generalitat's own statements frame this as a deliberate, escalating priority. What this section establishes is narrower and well-supported: for a substantial portion of the period this study examines, the practical cost of violating Barcelona's rent regulation was close to zero, and this enforcement gap coincided with — and plausibly enabled — the seasonal contract migration and coliving conversions documented throughout this report. The case study presented in this report describes a tenant relationship ending for reasons consistent with this same regulatory environment, at a moment when formal sanction mechanisms for room rental specifically were, for most of the period in question, not yet operative.

Sources cited in this chapter: 3Cat Info (2026); Govern.cat (2026); Sindicat de Llogateres (2026); Metròpoli Obert (2026).

Chapter 6: The Selective City — Who Barcelona Welcomes, and Who It Prices Out

Opening

The preceding chapters of this study documented a structural shift in how Barcelona's housing stock is contracted. This chapter examines who is driving demand for that shift, using the city's own demographic and migration statistics — structured to separate documented fact from this study's interpretation of what that fact implies.

Evidence

As of 1 January 2025, foreign nationals represent 26.4% of Barcelona's population, a historic high according to the city's municipal census (padrón). Including residents born abroad regardless of current nationality, the figure rises to 35.4% — 612,529 people.

The padrón further reports that 43.1% of foreign residents overall hold a university degree or equivalent qualification, rising to 65.5% among EU citizens specifically, and to 75.6% among American residents, 74.4% among French residents, 72.2% among British residents, and 70.6% among German residents. Comparable education or income statistics are not published in the same municipal releases for Barcelona's largest non-EU migrant communities by population — including Colombian, Pakistani, and other Latin American and South Asian nationalities.

Separately, Spain's Permanent Migration Observatory reports that Barcelona received over 30% of all remote-work residency permits granted nationally in 2024 — 6,401 permits, against 3,514 for Madrid — and that national digital nomad permits doubled between 2023 and 2024, from 9,537 to 19,771. The Observatory's own data notes that EU citizens, exempt from visa requirements, are not captured in this count.

Interpretation

This study interprets the gap in educational attainment between EU/North American residents and Barcelona's largest non-EU migrant communities as a proxy indicator — not a direct measurement — of income stratification within the city's foreign population. Educational attainment correlates with income and with eligibility for high-paying remote work, but it is not income itself, and the padrón does not provide a more direct measure.

The absence of comparable demographic detail for Barcelona's largest non-EU communities in the same official communications is interpreted here as suggestive of an asymmetry in how the city's foreign population is publicly characterised, rather than as proof of differential treatment in any specific housing transaction. This study does not have access to rental application data, landlord selection criteria, or refusal rates by nationality, and therefore cannot demonstrate discrimination directly. What it can demonstrate, using only the city's own published statistics, is that Barcelona's foreign population is demographically and economically stratified, and that the fastest-growing segment of that population — digital nomads and remote-work residents — is documented as disproportionately drawn from high-income countries.

Mechanism

The proposed mechanism connecting this demographic evidence to the housing market findings elsewhere in this study is as follows: a resident population with access to foreign remote salaries, often denominated in stronger currencies, can sustain rental payments that represent a small fraction of their income, while the same payment represents a much larger fraction of a local or low-income migrant salary. Where housing supply is constrained, landlords choosing between a high-income

transient tenant and a lower-income long-term tenant face a straightforward economic incentive to prefer the former, independent of any discriminatory intent.

This study treats this as one mechanism contributing to the housing pressure documented throughout this report, operating alongside — not instead of — the seasonal contract shift (Chapter 4) and the tourism-driven pressure on specific neighbourhoods (Chapter 3). It does not claim this is the dominant or sole driver of Barcelona's housing crisis, nor does it quantify its relative weight against these other factors, in the absence of data that would permit such a comparison.

Methodological Note

The interpretive step from "Barcelona's foreign population is income-stratified" to "this stratification meaningfully affects housing access for low-income migrants" is, in this section, supported by demographic correlation and economic plausibility rather than by transaction-level evidence. The case study presented in this report offers one first-person account consistent with this mechanism — a researcher with documented income sufficient to cover formal rental costs, who nonetheless experienced near-total exclusion from formal, contracted tenancy across six years. This single account cannot establish how widespread this experience is. It is presented as a mechanism-exposing case: evidence that the structural pathway described in this section is at minimum operative in practice, not merely theoretical.

Closing

This section does not prove that any individual landlord made decisions based on nationality or income for any individual tenant. It establishes, using Barcelona's own demographic and migration statistics, that the city's foreign population is sharply stratified by income proxy, that its fastest-growing segment is disproportionately high-income and transient, and that this stratification provides a plausible, economically rational mechanism connecting demand-side population change to the supply-side contraction in long-term rental housing documented elsewhere in this study. Two patterns — a constrained long-term migrant workforce and an expanding high-income transient population — are observable within the same housing market and the same time period. This study's data does not establish that one caused the other; it establishes that both are occurring simultaneously, in a market with limited overall supply, where landlords face a direct economic incentive to prioritise tenants able to pay a premium for short-term flexibility. The term "housing crisis" is commonly used to describe insufficient supply. The data in this chapter suggests it should also be understood as a question of distribution: who the existing supply is increasingly allocated to, independent of how long any given resident has lived in or contributed to the city.

Sources cited in this chapter: Ajuntament de Barcelona / Barcelona International Welcome (2025); TotBarcelona (2024); Catalan News (2025), citing the Observatorio Permanente de la Inmigración.

Case Study: A Six-Year Housing Trajectory (2020-2026)

Methodological Framing

This case study is presented as a first-person account situated within the informal housing market described throughout this report. It is not intended to represent the average experience of tenants in Barcelona, nor to serve as statistically representative evidence. It is included as a *mechanism-exposing case*: a structured individual trajectory illustrating how the housing market dynamics identified in this study's aggregate data operate at the level of lived experience.

The purpose of this section is not to establish prevalence or quantify outcomes, but to document how the structural conditions described elsewhere in this study — the absence of formal contracts, the expansion of unregulated room rental, and the limits of any institutional enforcement mechanism — manifest in practice within a single, continuous housing trajectory.

Housing Trajectory

Quantitative data on Barcelona's rental market captures prices, contracts, and aggregate trends. It does not capture what it feels like to search for a home in a city that has quietly priced out the people who sustain it.

In February 2020, this researcher arrived in Barcelona with no savings, no contract, and no formal housing arranged — a common starting point for the low-wage migrant workers who staff the city's bars, restaurants, and hotels, and who remain largely invisible in the official data measuring the crisis they live inside. Within weeks, the COVID-19 lockdown closed the city entirely. The first months were spent in a friend's home, unpaid, with no rental agreement of any kind — an informal safety net made possible by personal goodwill rather than any institutional protection, and one not everyone in the same position would have had.

What followed, once the city reopened, was a six-year search for stable housing across eleven different rooms and apartments. Each move came with the same quiet calculation that anyone navigating this market learns to make: not "is this a good home," but "is this survivable, and for how long."

A small windowless room near Hospital Clínic, €350/month, lasted two months. A larger room near Sagrada Família, also €350, ended without warning when police entered the apartment during an unannounced inspection: the landlord had been illegally subletting an occupied property and had never disclosed this to the tenant. With one hour's notice, the tenant was on the street with her belongings, sitting on the curb with nowhere arranged to go. The landlord disappeared and was never held accountable — a disappearance made possible precisely because no contract, no registry, and no public authority had ever recorded that the tenancy existed.

A mattress on the floor in a shared apartment in Lesseps, €300/month, ended after a housemate's partner objected to the tenant's perceived sexual orientation — a reminder that housing insecurity for migrants is rarely only economic. A windowless room in Raval, €400/month, in a visibly deteriorating building, lasted one month. A single-bed room in Horta, €350/month, lasted one more. A friend's couch, offered without charge, provided a month of respite — and a month of dependence on someone else's generosity, the closest thing to a safety net this market offers.

A return to the Lesseps room — now €350, the previous partner having left — provided approximately eight months of relative stability, despite ongoing substance use by the resident landlord that made the home feel unstable in different, quieter ways. Another month was spent on a friend's couch in the Gothic Quarter.

The longest single arrangement, approximately eighteen months, was a room near Verdaguer station, €400/month — nominally furnished with a bed, wardrobe, and desk, in an apartment the landlord had subdivided into eight rooms sharing two bathrooms in advanced disrepair. Cooking was abandoned entirely; the kitchen was infested and uncleaned. The bathrooms remained in a state no resident would describe as habitable. Complaints to the landlord changed nothing — there was no incentive for him to act, and no authority compelling him to. For eighteen months, this was simply what home meant.

The current residence, secured approximately two years ago, is the only formalised arrangement of the eleven: a registered rental contract, shared with two housemates, professional cleaning, and conditions that finally felt like dignity rather than survival — located in Nou Barris, a peripheral district chosen because the city centre was, by then, financially out of reach. The rent is €500/month.

Aggregate Pattern

Across eleven housing arrangements over six years, ten were informal and only one was formally contracted. Only one offered legal tenancy protection. Only one treated the tenant as someone with enforceable rights, rather than someone who would simply leave quietly when things went wrong.

That single landlord — the only one who registered the tenancy and declared it for tax purposes — has now informed the tenant of her intention to stop renting rooms once the current arrangement ends. Under Catalonia's 2023 housing legislation, the tax burden on declared short-term contracts has made formal room rental financially unviable for small-scale landlords. The policy written to protect tenants is, in this case, dismantling the only example of regulated, sanitary, legally protected tenancy this researcher encountered in six years — while doing nothing to touch the landlords who operated entirely outside the system throughout.

The absence of formal contracts across the majority of these arrangements meant that standard institutional mechanisms — dispute resolution, housing inspection, tenant protection — were structurally inaccessible, not merely underused. In practice, this produced a trajectory shaped primarily by availability and affordability within the informal room rental market, rather than by any regulated tenancy right.

Structural Interpretation

This sequence is not presented as representative of all tenants in Barcelona. It is interpreted here as consistent with the structural conditions documented throughout this study: a housing market in which a significant share of rental activity occurs outside formal regulation, particularly within subdivided apartments and informal room rental arrangements.

This sequence illustrates a structural gap between the protections a housing policy is designed to provide and the population segment most likely to need them. A law can cap a contract price and still leave a tenant sitting on a curb with an hour's notice, because the contract never existed to begin with. It can declare zones "tensioned" while the room rental market — where the most economically precarious tenants actually live — remains entirely unmeasured, ungoverned, and unseen by the same institutions evaluating the policy's success.

Without formal regulation of this segment of the market, a significant population experiences housing instability despite technically having access to shelter. Having a bed does not, on its own, indicate housing stability. Constraints on income, time, and available alternatives lead many tenants — this researcher included — to accept available housing regardless of its condition, given the absence of viable alternatives.

What made each of these situations endurable, and at the same time degrading, was the absence of any institution to appeal to. There is no housing authority to file a complaint with when there is no

contract proving you ever lived there. There is no inspection to request when the tenancy itself is invisible to the system. The tenant's only available strategy is to pay quietly, say nothing, and accept whatever conditions are imposed — because the moment a tenant raises a problem, the landlord's simplest response is to make them leave, with no paper trail and no consequence. These conditions indicate a form of housing access operating almost entirely outside standard regulatory and legal protection, producing outcomes consistent with survival-level insecurity rather than stable tenancy — governed, in practice, by the tenant's silence rather than by any enforceable right.

Paying significant amounts for a single, often substandard room is, for many, not a matter of choice but the only door still open. This is not primarily a question of affordability — many tenants paying €500 for a room could, in principle, afford a self-contained studio at the same price. It is a question of access. The room rental market is not a cheaper alternative to the formal rental market; for a significant share of migrants, it is the only segment of the market they are permitted to enter at all, regardless of what they can pay.

This exclusion appears to operate on economic profile rather than on nationality itself. Long-term, lower-income tenants seeking housing stability are, in this researcher's experience, frequently asked for guarantees — income proof, permanent contracts, local guarantors — that short-term, higher-income foreign residents are rarely required to provide. The asymmetry is observable in practice: a long-term resident integrating into local employment and language faces stricter screening criteria than a short-term visitor whose stay carries lower perceived risk to the landlord, regardless of relative ability to pay. This selective screening pattern is consistent with the demographic stratification documented in Chapter 6 of this study.

Mechanism-Exposing Function of the Case

This case study is included as a mechanism-exposing case rather than as statistically representative evidence. Its function is to illustrate how the structural conditions described in aggregate data throughout this study — the prevalence of informal rental arrangements, limited contractual protection, and enforcement asymmetries — operate at the level of an individual, lived housing trajectory.

It does not establish how widespread this pattern is within Barcelona's rental market. It does establish that the mechanisms this study describes are not theoretical or purely statistical abstractions: they were lived directly, across ten of eleven arrangements, over six consecutive years.

Closing Note

This trajectory is presented as a mechanism-exposing case rather than as statistically representative evidence: a single account cannot establish how common this pattern is across Barcelona's room rental sector. What it can establish is plausibility — that the structural conditions this study documents at the level of aggregate data (the absence of formal contracts, the fiscal disincentive to declare seasonal tenancy, the exclusion from formal housing independent of income) are not theoretical. They were lived directly, across ten of eleven informal arrangements, over six consecutive years. If this trajectory reflects even a fraction of Barcelona's room rental sector, the data gap identified throughout this study is not a methodological limitation. It is the mechanism through which the crisis sustains itself — unmeasured, unregulated, and therefore absent from the very statistics policymakers rely on to evaluate the law's success.

Chapter 7: Policy Recommendations

Opening

The preceding chapters of this study documented three interlocking mechanisms: a measurable divergence between regulated and market rental prices, a rapid migration of supply from long-term to seasonal and room-based tenancy, and a demographic asymmetry in who Barcelona's housing market increasingly serves. This closing chapter does not propose a single solution to a single problem. It proposes a coordinated set of interventions, each addressing a specific mechanism documented in this report, on the understanding that a policy targeting only one mechanism — as the original 2023 law largely did — leaves the others available as pressure valves through which the underlying crisis continues unabated.

Evidence

Several of the gaps this study identifies are already, partially, subjects of policy action. As documented in Chapter 4, Catalonia extended price regulation to room and seasonal contracts in January 2026, directly responding to the loophole this and other research has documented. As documented in Chapter 5, enforcement capacity expanded substantially between early and mid-2026, following sustained pressure from tenant organisations. Spain's national social housing stock remains, per OECD and Eurostat data, among the lowest in the EU as a share of total housing — a structural undersupply this study has referenced but not analysed in depth. Barcelona's Ajuntament has announced a phase-out of tourist apartment licences by 2028, though this study has not independently verified enforcement capacity for that measure specifically.

Interpretation

These existing and announced measures address some of the mechanisms documented in this study, but not all, and not yet at sufficient scale or speed to have altered this researcher's own housing trajectory, which continued through 2026 despite the January regulatory extension. This study interprets the existing policy response as directionally correct but structurally incomplete: it has, so far, regulated each loophole only after it had already produced years of measurable harm, rather than anticipating the economic incentives — particularly the fiscal asymmetry documented in Chapter 4 — that will likely generate the next loophole once the current ones close.

Recommendations

1. Close the fiscal incentive at its source, not only its symptom. Chapter 4 of this study documented that Spanish tax law taxes long-term rental income at a maximum of 50% of net income, while seasonal rental income is taxed at 100% but carries no price cap — creating a structural incentive for landlords to exit regulated tenancy regardless of any other factor. Extending price regulation to seasonal and room contracts, as Catalonia did in January 2026, addresses the price side of this asymmetry. It does not address the tax side. This study recommends equalising the tax treatment of long-term and seasonal rental income, removing the fiscal reward for contract restructuring independent of the price cap extension, so that no future contract category emerges as a more profitable, less regulated alternative once today's loopholes are closed.

2. Fund enforcement capacity at the level required for an 18,000-contract shift, not a 13-case pilot. Chapter 5 of this study documented that Catalonia's enforcement regime issued only 3 to 13 confirmed sanctions in its first 12 months, against a shift of over 18,000 contracts into the segment that regime was meant to govern. Enforcement activity scaled substantially by April 2026, but only after roughly 18 months of minimal practical risk for non-compliant landlords. This study recommends that enforcement capacity — staffing, investigation infrastructure, and sanctioning authority — be

funded and operational at the time a regulation enters into force, not built reactively in response to documented non-compliance after the fact.

3. Establish mandatory, granular data collection for room and seasonal rentals. This study's central methodological finding — echoed independently in the academic literature reviewed for this chapter — is that the segment of Barcelona's rental market growing fastest, and most likely to house its most economically precarious tenants, is also its least measured. Even INCASÒL's own registry, the most authoritative source available to this study, is estimated to capture roughly 60% of actual rental contracts nationally. This study recommends that the recently extended room and seasonal rental registration requirement be paired with public, disaggregated reporting — by neighbourhood, contract type, and price — at a frequency comparable to the existing INCASÒL long-term rental series.

4. Accelerate social housing delivery, treating it as a supply-side complement to price regulation, not an alternative to it. Price and contract-type regulation, as this study has shown, can constrain how existing housing stock is priced and contracted, but cannot by itself increase the stock available to long-term, lower-income residents. This study recommends that Barcelona and the Generalitat treat the expansion of public and below-market social housing as a necessary complement to the regulatory measures discussed above.

5. Create accessible, low-barrier reporting channels specifically for informal and undocumented tenancies. The case study presented in this report documented six years in which formal complaint or inspection mechanisms were structurally inaccessible, because no contract existed to document the tenancy in the first place. This study recommends the creation of a reporting channel — through existing tenant unions, municipal housing offices, or a dedicated hotline — explicitly designed to receive complaints from tenants in informal arrangements without requiring a contract as a precondition for the complaint to be processed, alongside protections preventing retaliatory eviction against tenants who report unsafe or exploitative conditions in undocumented tenancies.

Mechanism

Each of these five recommendations targets a specific incentive or capacity gap documented in this study, rather than the housing crisis in the abstract. Recommendation 1 removes a documented fiscal incentive. Recommendation 2 closes a documented enforcement gap. Recommendation 3 closes a documented data gap. Recommendation 4 addresses the supply constraint that price regulation alone cannot resolve. Recommendation 5 addresses the access-to-recourse gap this study's case study made directly visible. None of these recommendations, individually, would have prevented the trajectory described in this report. Implemented together, they would have removed several of the specific mechanisms — the tax incentive, the enforcement delay, the absence of a complaint channel — that allowed that trajectory to occur with no institutional friction at any point across eleven housing arrangements.

Closing

This study opened with a thesis: that Barcelona's housing crisis reflects not a shortage of housing, but a reconfiguration of tenancy regimes that systematically redirects access away from long-term residents toward high-income transient populations, through mechanisms that remain largely outside the law's current reach. The recommendations in this chapter do not claim to resolve that reconfiguration. They claim, more modestly and more verifiably, to close the specific structural gaps this study has documented with official data, independent academic research, and one tenant's six-year account of what those gaps feel like from the inside. Closing them would not end Barcelona's housing crisis. It would remove some of the mechanisms currently allowing that crisis to be measured, in official statistics, as smaller than it is.

Sources cited in this chapter: Orozco-Martínez & Gil-Alonso (2024); Cocola-Gant, Hodkinson & Janoschka (2025); all sources previously cited in Chapters 4, 5, and 6.

Closing

This study began with a number that, on its own, sounds unremarkable: average rent in Barcelona rose from €9.54 to €15.61 per square metre between 2014 and 2025, according to the city's own official contract registry. It ends with a finding that complicates how that number should be read: this is not the figure that determines whether a resident can currently find housing in the city.

The real number — the one advertised, the one negotiated, the one a tenant actually pays — reached €23.75 per square metre in the same year, according to market data compared directly against the same official series. The gap between these two figures is the central empirical finding of this report. It coincides closely with the period in which seasonal rental contracts increased nearly fivefold, enforcement of the regulation issued single-digit sanctions in its first operational year, and the demographic composition of Barcelona's fastest-growing foreign population shifted toward higher-income, shorter-stay residents.

None of these patterns, individually, fully explains a trajectory involving eleven housing arrangements across six years for a tenant with stable income. Considered together, as this study has attempted to do, they provide a more complete account than any single dataset could on its own.

Throughout this report, an effort has been made to separate what the available data demonstrates from what it suggests, and to flag explicitly where this study's conclusions rely on correlation, documented mechanism, or qualitative illustration rather than isolated causal proof. This approach does not weaken the central finding. It is possible to state, with the evidence assembled here, that Barcelona's rent regulation achieved a measurable, documented reduction in the rate of price growth within the contracts it directly governs — a real and verifiable policy outcome — while a substantial and growing share of the rental market shifted into contract types the regulation did not yet reach. Both statements are true simultaneously, and this study has aimed to hold them together rather than resolve them into a single verdict on the policy's success or failure.

This study has identified specific, named mechanisms — a fiscal incentive favouring seasonal contracts over long-term ones, an initial enforcement gap of approximately twelve to eighteen months, and a data collection framework that does not yet capture the room and seasonal rental market in the detail it captures long-term contracts. Each of these is, in principle, addressable through the policy measures outlined in the preceding chapter. This study does not claim to resolve Barcelona's housing crisis. It aims to document, with the most rigorous evidence available within its scope, where specific structural gaps remain open, and to provide a basis from which more targeted policy responses — and further research — might proceed.

Prepared as an independent data analysis study. Methodology, sources, and full dataset documentation available upon request.